Amir was recognising that for the time being the game was up and a new regional force had emerged. He clearly hoped that the British might sooner or later bring him back as ruler, or that their ultimate defeat would provide opportunities for his return on his own in the future. It was to prove a canny calculation.[100]

Arrangements were swiftly made to convey the Amir to India. He would be given a generous pension and reunited with his harem, who were then being held in the fortress of Ghazni. It was soon agreed that he should be given Shah Shuja's vacated quarters in Ludhiana, as Shuja's harem were shortly due to leave for Kabul. Unexpectedly, in the nine days he stayed in Kabul, Macnaghten and the Amir became friends: 'The candle of intercourse and conversation burned brightly between them,' noted Mirza 'Ata.[101] Macnaghten even intervened on the Amir's behalf with Auckland. 'I trust the Dost will be treated with liberality,' he wrote. 'His case has been compared to that of Shah Shuja; and I have seen it argued that he should not be treated more handsomely than His Majesty was; but surely the cases are not parallel. The Shah has no claim upon us. We had no hand in depriving him of his Kingdom, whereas we ejected the Dost, who never offended us, in support of our policy, of which he was the victim.'[102] It was the closest Macnaghten would ever come to admitting that 'the gallant old Ameer', who had always been friendly to the English, had been quite unnecessarily deprived of his throne and his kingdom.

The Amir was so pleased and relieved by his honourable surrender to the British, and the way in which he had been able to prove his valour on the field of Parwan Darra before he did so, that he was prepared to forgive even Burnes, whom everyone else in the Barakzai camp regarded as a devious and slippery *namak haram* [literally 'impure salt' – a serious insult, meaning one who had played traitor to his host]. As Burnes wrote to a friend,

> My interview with Dost Mohammad was very interesting and very affectionate. He taunted me with nothing, said I was his best friend, and that he had come in on a letter I had written to him. This I disbelieve, for we followed him from house to house [through Kohistan] and he was obliged to surrender. On that letter, however, I hope I have got for him an annual stipend of two lakhs of rupees instead of one. On our parting I gave him an Arab horse; and what do you think he gave me? His own, and only sword, which is stained with blood. He left for India . . . and is to live at Ludhiana. In Kohistan I saw a failure of our artillery to breach, of our European soldiers to storm, and of our cavalry to charge; and yet God gave us the victory . . . If we could turn over a new leaf here, we might yet make Afghanistan a barrier.[103]